PRODUCT WORK

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INSIDE: *Live product access · 3 case studies from 10k Athletics · Supporting work · Five-pillar summary*

Executive Summary

This packet is a short tour of applied product work, built around three case studies from 10k Athletics, the sports-tech platform I founded and lead as Product Lead. It also includes one piece of evidence the case studies cannot replace: live access to the product itself.

My recommendation for how to read this packet is simple. Open the live product first (Exhibit A below). Five minutes inside 10k Athletics will demonstrate more about how I think than any narrative I can write. The case studies that follow exist to make the reasoning behind specific decisions legible: the marketplace payment-flow work, a 0-DAU activation diagnosis, and a feature-scoping decision with real engineering tradeoffs.

The argument of this submission is that the work I have done at 10k Athletics (building a two-sided marketplace from zero, owning a complete product roadmap, diagnosing a 0-DAU launch, and making explicit build-vs-buy tradeoffs on payment infrastructure) develops the product judgment a strong APM role requires: discovery under ambiguity, prioritization with limited data, and ownership of outcomes rather than output. The candidacy is summarized on five pillars at the close of this document.

> **EXHIBIT A: LIVE PRODUCT ACCESS · 10K ATHLETICS**
>
> The fastest way to evaluate my product work is to use the product directly. 10k Athletics is live on the App Store, with active users at Regis University and onboarding underway for our first creator marketplace partner.
>
> **Player app (iOS, App Store):** apps.apple.com/us/app/10k-athletics/id6751750374
>
> **Web platform:** 10kathletics.com
>
> **Sign-up access code:** TEST

Situation: 10k Athletics

10k Athletics is a sports-tech platform built around individual development plans (IDPs) for athletes. The product comprises three connected services: a player app for daily training and progression, a team software for coaches, and a creator marketplace where coaches, trainers, and content creators sell digital programs and services to athletes.

I founded the company in 2022, raised $45,000 in non-dilutive and incubator capital (Magis Factory Incubator and the Regis Innovation Challenge, where the company placed 2nd and won $5,000), and currently lead product end-to-end across discovery, roadmap, design partnership, and delivery with a small team of designers

and engineers. The platform launched on the App Store and is live with student-athletes and coaches at Regis University, with onboarding underway for our first creator marketplace partner, Matt Sheldon of Become Elite.

Dimension	Detail
Product surface area	Player app (iOS), web platform, team software, creator marketplace
Pilot cohort	Regis University men's and women's soccer (50+ early users)
First marketplace creator	Matt Sheldon, Become Elite (signed Q1 2026)
Stack	React, React Native, FastAPI, Supabase / Postgres, Stripe Connect
Funding to date	$45,000 (Magis Factory Incubator + Regis Innovation Challenge)
My role	Founder and Product Lead. Discovery, roadmap, prioritization, delivery.

Case Study 1: Designing payment flows in a two-sided marketplace

DISCOVERY · RISK-AWARE PRIORITIZATION · BUILD-VS-BUY

Situation

Stripe Connect made it easy to take payments. It did not, on its own, answer the harder questions a marketplace has to resolve: who is allowed to list and get paid, when a payout actually clears, how 10k recovers money it has fronted on a creator's behalf, and how disputes are handled without breaking trust on either side. That layer had to be designed.

Approach

- **Mapped the full money flow** from a player's first purchase through payout to the creator, identifying every state in which money is held, in dispute, or at risk of being clawed back.
- **Defined the data model** for creators (verification status, Stripe onboarding state, setup-service debt) and transactions (commission split, payout eligibility, refund handling) so engineering had a single specification to build against.
- **Wrote the business rules** for edge cases: incomplete Stripe onboarding, mid-purchase tier upgrades, refunds, suspended creators, and the recovery of the $500 platform setup-service balance from a creator's first marketplace earnings.
- **Made an explicit build-vs-buy call** to lean on Stripe Connect for identity verification (Know Your Customer / KYC), payouts, and dispute primitives rather than rebuilding them. The spec documents exactly which risks Stripe handles versus which 10k still owns at the application layer.

Outcome

The marketplace payment specification is the operating document engineering builds against today. Matt Sheldon was onboarded against this spec as the first marketplace creator in Q1 2026.

What this demonstrates

Designing creator verification rules and payout eligibility is the same kind of judgment call that shows up in any risk-adjacent product decision: every false positive (a legitimate creator delayed) costs trust, and every false negative (a bad actor paid out) costs money. The lesson I took from this work is that the goal is not zero risk; it is

making the trade-offs visible enough that the business can choose them deliberately. That framing transfers cleanly to any product surface where payment, trust, fraud, or compliance constraints shape the experience.

Case Study 2: Diagnosing a 0-DAU launch

CUSTOMER DISCOVERY · EVIDENCE OVER INSTINCT · ACTIVATION FRAMING

Situation

After launching the player app to the Regis pilot cohort, daily active users sat at zero for the first stretch. Sign-ups were happening; engagement was not. My first instinct was to build a leaderboard to drive habit formation. I did not ship it, and I am glad I did not.

Approach

- **Resisted building.** A leaderboard is a retention mechanic, and we did not have a retention problem yet; we had an activation problem. Adding gamification on top of an empty app would have created a ghost-town effect that obscured the real diagnostic signal.
- **Sent a structured survey** to the test cohort to gather signal before changing the product.
- **Ran live onboarding sessions** with the Regis coaches: watching them sign up in real time surfaced friction in seconds that no survey would have caught.
- **Did 1:1 conversations with players** rather than a focus group, because group settings suppress honest feedback. The framing question I used: “What would need to be true for you to open this app tomorrow morning?” The answers reframed the problem from “the app needs more features” to “the app needs a single, obvious activation moment in the first session.”
- **Defined a clear activation event** as the success metric (the one action that signals a player has understood the value of the product), and reordered the roadmap around getting users to that moment.

Outcome

The roadmap was reordered around activation rather than retention features, and the leaderboard was deferred until the activation problem was solved. The most important deliverable from this work was the discipline of letting evidence change the prioritization.

What this demonstrates

This is the loop most APM job descriptions ask for in different words: use product data, customer input, and market signals to surface opportunities, then translate those insights into problem statements worth solving. This case study is exactly that loop: a surface-level metric (DAU) that pointed at the wrong intervention (gamification), corrected by primary research into the actual problem (activation). The hardest part of product work is being willing to sit with zero numbers for a week, gather evidence, and let it change your mind. That is the muscle I most want to keep building.

Case Study 3: Scoping the Drill Builder feature

ROADMAP TRADEOFFS · BUILD-VS-BUY · CROSS-TEAM ALIGNMENT

Situation

Coaches in the pilot were asking for a way to design and share visual drill diagrams (a drag-and-drop whiteboard for training plans). The need was real, but the engineering scope (canvas, animation timeline, export pipeline,

sport-specific templates) was an order of magnitude larger than anything else on the roadmap. The decision was whether to build, integrate, or postpone.

Approach

- **Sized the opportunity across all three services**: player (assigned drills with diagrams), team (practice planning), and creator marketplace (creators selling visual drill packs). The marketplace cut was where the long-term strategic value sat.
- **Compared three paths explicitly:** custom build (full control, deep marketplace integration, long timeline), third-party embed (fast to ship, dependency risk, weak marketplace integration), and a hybrid (ship a static diagram builder first, add animation as a premium feature later).
- **Recommended the hybrid path** because it preserved the strategic upside (drills as first-class marketplace content) while keeping v1 scope honest, and gave the team a real artifact to test with creators before committing engineering to the animation layer.

Outcome

The decision is in the current roadmap. More importantly, the framing separates the strategic question (do drills become a marketplace primitive?) from the execution question (how do we ship a useful first version this quarter?), which is the same framing that travels to any product team where long-term capability and short-term shipping pull against each other.

Supporting Work

These are earlier roles where I shipped real systems against real user problems. They are not PM work in title, but they are where I learned to pair a clear user problem with a working build.

Engagement	Role & Outcome	Link
The Farm FC (2023–2024)	Designed and shipped the public site, then built backend systems for CRM workflows, customer data organization, and an internal order-tracking tool that gave staff operational visibility they did not have before.	thefarmfc.com
SIQ Soccer Academy (2019–2022)	Rebuilt the academy site, partnered with an SEO firm to restructure content and information architecture, and contributed to the digital marketing stack supporting growth.	siqacademy.com
WSi Healthcare (2024–2025)	Marketing intern: executed a social strategy across 40+ targeted posts and conducted market research to support recruiting outreach.	Internal role

Why this candidacy is defensible: Five Pillars

#	Finding	Why it matters for a product role
1	Three years of end-to-end product ownership at 10k Athletics: discovery, MVP definition, roadmap, App Store launch with 50+ early users, first marketplace creator signed.	Clears the typical “1+ years product experience” bar comfortably and demonstrates the full discover, execute, own loop that APM job descriptions consistently ask for.

#	Finding	Why it matters for a product role
2	Built a Stripe Connect marketplace from zero, including identity verification, payout eligibility, and risk-decision rules.	The closest analogue in my background to fraud, trust, and risk-adjacent product work. The judgment muscle (false-positive vs. false-negative trade-offs) transfers to any product surface where bad-actor risk and friction sit in tension.
3	Diagnosed a 0-DAU launch by resisting the obvious build, running primary research, and re-prioritizing around an activation event.	Direct evidence of strong analytical skills, comfort with ambiguous problems, and evidence-based decision-making, all of which are standard requirements for early-career product roles.
4	Finance + CS background (Finance B.S., CS minor, Applied AI M.S. in progress); working SQL, Python, React, Postgres.	Covers the typical "business, design, or engineering degree" requirement and the "data analysis, SQL, or Python is a plus" line that shows up in most APM postings. Comfortable in technical conversations with engineers.
5	Coaching JV/Varsity at Kent Denver in parallel with running 10k Athletics and finishing a Finance degree at a 3.7 GPA.	Operates against compressed timelines with multiple stakeholders. The hands-on, bias-for-action posture most product teams want is the day-to-day reality of this profile.

Trade-offs Acknowledged

Intellectual honesty requires naming what this candidacy does not bring. I have not worked inside a large product organization with established research, design, and engineering functions, and would be learning team-scale product process from a standing start. I have not used the standard product-analytics stack (Segment, Amplitude, Mixpanel, PostHog, Iterable) in a production setting, though I am familiar with the categories and would close that gap quickly. My experience is broad and self-directed rather than deep and specialized.

What this candidacy does bring is a builder's track record on a real product with real users and real money flowing through it, an engineering vocabulary that lets me move fast with technical teams, and a documented habit of letting evidence (not instinct) drive prioritization. Those are the muscles that compound. Domain knowledge can be acquired in the first 90 days; the judgment cannot.

Closing

If you have only a few minutes with this packet: open 10k Athletics on the web or download it from the App Store, sign up with access code TEST, and use the product. The case studies above are there so that, when specific questions surface, the reasoning behind each decision is already on paper.

I am happy to walk through any of this work in more depth: the marketplace payment architecture, the activation diagnosis, or anything else worth a longer conversation.

Respectfully submitted, ***Blake Wellington***